ROBERT H. SMITH SCHOOL OF BUSINESS

AI for Small Business Hack-a-thon – Fall 2026

Program Details, Rules and Guidelines

The Challenge

Small businesses, such as mom & pop restaurants, coffee shops, HVAC techs, and landscaping companies, can benefit from AI but struggle finding the right tools.

The Ask

Design and build a prototype of a platform to help small businesses discover, compare and adopt AI tools.

Students are expected to establish a team to research and develop a platform that can be used by non-technical small business users to explore available AI solutions, select appropriate solutions and deploy them for their business.

One way to think of this platform is as an "Angie's List" of AI solutions that a small business can review and choose from. It shows what AI tools are available and their rating. It also shows what the AI tool will cost and how the small business can engage with the AI tool. The platform differs from "Angie's List" in that AI tools need to be discovered by the platform. The rating of an AI tool needs to be beyond reviews and a small business might need to integrate multiple AI tools for their solution.

The Deliverable

- Record 10 minute video showcasing the following –
    - Proof of concept of a minimum viable product (MVP) of the platform,
    - How you approached building it
    - How you would tackle the challenge if given 16 weeks to complete it
    - Evidence that the concept is technically possible and valuable
- Submit link to the prototype that judges can access and test
- Winning teams will give final presentations in-person on November 17.

Timeline

- **Thursday, November 5, 12pm:** Release competition information
- **Thursday, November 5, 6 pm:** Q&A with Dr. Balaji Padmanabhan and Dr. Tej Anand
- **Friday, November 6:** Teams begin to build products/presentations
- **Sunday, November 8, 11:59pm:** Video demonstration submitted to designated google drive
- **Monday, November 16, 12pm:** Finalists will be notified to make final in-person presentation
- **Tuesday, November 17, 5-8pm:** Final in-person presentations for invited teams only (10-12 minutes, including Q&A). Pizza and drinks will be provided.

Who Can Participate

Undergraduate and graduate students from any major are welcome.

Rules and Guidelines

- Each team must consist of at least 2, but not more than 3, members.
- Students may only compete on **ONE** team.
- Coaching from faculty, staff, or outside experts is acceptable as long as it is acknowledged/ cited in presentation materials
- Teams are expected to conduct research using metrics that they determine are suitable
- To be eligible for prize money, teams must make final presentation in-person on Nov 17.
- ***For intellectual property considerations, all students participating in the AISB Hack-a-thon acknowledge that all rights, title and interests in and to submissions to the Hack-a-thon, including any deliverables, belong exclusively to the University of Maryland as a condition of participation.***

Final Presentation Criteria

Judges will score on a 50-point scale using these criteria:

- ***Depth of research (10 points)***
  Teams show a strong understanding of the following –
  - type of platform(s) envisaged and
  - needs of small businesses
- ***Quality of the Most Viable Product (MVP) (30 points, based on 3 categories)***
  - **Small Business Applicability (10 points)** - How well the platform's functionality meets the needs of a diverse set of small businesses, integrates with legacy technology they already use, and perhaps leverages other offerings from the US Small Business Administration.
  - **Architecture and Scalability (10 points)** - How well the platform's architecture and technical choices would support more users, data, or use cases
  - **User Experience (10 points)** - How easily a first-time user can understand the platform and complete tasks based on clarity, intuitiveness, and accessibility
- ***Demonstration and presentation (10 points)***
  Teams deliver a professional, polished presentation with clear points, and an indication of meaningful contributions from each team member

Why Join

- **Prizes totaling up to $25,000**
- **Up to ten teams selected for final, in-person presentations on November 17**
- **Minimum prize for all finalist teams is $1,500**
- Awardees may be considered for **paid student appointments** (up to 10 hrs/week through Summer 2027) building AI tools for small businesses.
- Participants will enhance their ability to work in diverse teams.
- Participants will gain experience relevant to their future careers.

Questions? Contact us at smith-club-smsa@umd.edu

Principal Investigators

Dr. Balaji Padmanabhan
Associate Dean of Strategic Initiatives
Director, Center for AI in Business

Dr. Tej Anand
Clinical Professor
Academic Director, MS in Information Systems & AI